



Six Thinking Hats

Think in one direction at a time, together.

Each hat is one way of thinking. The whole group wears the same hat at the same time.



White Hat

Facts and information

What do we know, and what do we need to find out?

USE IT TO

Collect facts and numbers.
Name what is missing.

COMMON MISTAKE

Saying an opinion as if it were a fact.



Red Hat

Feelings and gut sense

What is my gut feeling about this?

USE IT TO

Share a hunch in a few words. No reasons needed.

COMMON MISTAKE

Asking people to explain or defend their feelings.



Black Hat

Risks and problems

What could go wrong with this idea?

USE IT TO

Find the weak spots before they cost you.

COMMON MISTAKE

Using it too early, so a new idea dies before it can grow.



Yellow Hat

Benefits and value

What good could come from this idea?

USE IT TO

Look for value, even in ideas you don't like.

COMMON MISTAKE

Listing benefits without saying why they are real.



Green Hat

New ideas

What else could we try?

USE IT TO

Add options, change one part, combine ideas.

COMMON MISTAKE

Judging new ideas before they are fully shared.



Blue Hat

The process

What is our goal, and which hat do we need next?

USE IT TO

Set the goal, keep time, sum up. Anyone can call it.

COMMON MISTAKE

Skipping it. Without a goal and a plan, the meeting drifts.

How to use it

1

Open with the Blue Hat. Name the goal of the meeting and the order of the hats.

2

Wear one hat at a time. Everyone thinks in the same direction for a few minutes. Then move to the next hat.

3

Close with the Blue Hat. Sum up what you learned and agree on the next steps.

Across cultures: where open disagreement can make someone lose face, the hats help. A concern belongs to the Black Hat, not to the person who says it. Try the Yellow Hat before the Black Hat. Based on Edward de Bono, *Six Thinking Hats* (1985).